

Hunger

Companion Texts

A reading companion to Knut Hamsun's novel

The Invention of the Interior

Before there was stream of consciousness, there was starvation. Before the novel learned to follow the erratic, self-interrupting, associative tumble of a mind thinking, it had to find a mind under enough pressure to crack open and become visible to itself. In 1890, thirty-two years before

Joyce published *Ulysses* and thirty-five years before Woolf gave us *Mrs Dalloway*, a twenty-nine-year-old Norwegian named Knut Hamsun produced a short novel that did something no work of fiction had done before: it made the inside of a skull the entire landscape of the story. There is no plot in *Hunger* in any conventional sense. A young writer wanders the streets of Christiania, starving. He tries to write. He fails, or succeeds, and the success and the failure feel equally delirious. He gives away what little he has. He lies to strangers. He falls half in love. He sleeps in the woods. And none of this matters as action, as event, because the real subject is the wild, ungovernable weather of his consciousness, the way thought itself becomes the only drama worth recording.

The Room, the Newspaper, the Light

Consider how the novel begins. One sentence of scene-setting, a single line so compressed it functions almost as an epigraph:

It was during the time I wandered about and starved in Christiania: Christiania, this singular city, from which no man departs without carrying away the traces of his sojourn there.

Then an abrupt cut, a horizontal rule, and we are in a room. Not a room described from the outside, as Balzac or Dickens might have described it, furnishing every surface with social meaning. We are inside the narrator's consciousness as he wakes, and the room comes to us only as he perceives it, piece by piece, detail by unreliable detail:

I was lying awake in my attic and I heard a clock below strike six. It was already broad daylight, and people had begun to go up and down the stairs. By the door where the wall of the room was papered with old numbers of the *Morgenbladet*, I could distinguish clearly a notice from the Director of Lighthouses, and a little to the left of that an inflated advertisement of Fabian Olsens' new-baked bread.

A lighthouse director's notice and an advertisement for bread. These are not accidental details. The writer lives inside other people's language. His walls are literally papered with text he did not write, the published words of others, and the first thing his eyes seek in the morning is something to read. The bread advertisement is almost sadistic in its proximity to a starving man, but Hamsun does not underline this. The narrator does not comment on the cruelty of waking to the word "bread" when you have none. He simply sees it, registers it, moves on. The restraint is everything. In a naturalist novel,

this detail would have been wielded like a hammer. Here it just exists, the way details exist in a mind before the mind has decided what to feel about them.

And then the room itself, drawn not as a set of dimensions but as a set of sensations:

The bare room, the floor of which rocked up and down with every step I took across it, seemed like a gasping, sinister coffin. There was no proper fastening to the door, either, and no stove. I used to lie on my socks at night to dry them a little by the morning. The only thing I had to divert myself with was a little red rocking-chair, in which I used to sit in the evenings and doze and muse on all manner of things.

The floor that "rocked up and down" like breathing, the room as coffin, the rocking chair as the sole furniture of thought. This is already, on the first page, a new kind of writing. The room is not described; it is experienced. It is perceived as the body perceives things when the body is weak and hungry and the boundary between self and world has begun to dissolve. The rocking chair will return at the end of Part I, remembered with scorn when the narrator is high on the delusion that his fortunes have turned. But here, at the start, it is simply the site of consciousness: the place where the narrator sits and muses, the only object in his life that invites interiority.

The Whisper of Blood

In 1890, the same year *Hunger* was published in full, Hamsun delivered a lecture and wrote an essay called "From the Unconscious Life of the Mind." In it, he attacked the reigning gods of Scandinavian letters, argued against the heavy social machinery of Ibsen and the naturalist school, and demanded that literature attend to what he called "the whisper of blood and the pleading of bone marrow." He wanted fiction to register the irrational, the fleeting, the contradictory, the thoughts that arrive from nowhere and vanish before they can be examined. He wanted novels about minds, not about problems.

Part I of *Hunger* is the laboratory in which this theory becomes practice. Watch the narrator step outside into the streets of Christiania for the first time:

The roll of vehicles and hum of voices filled the air, a mighty morning-choir mingled with the footsteps of the pedestrians, and the crack of the hack-drivers' whips. The clamorous traffic everywhere exhilarated me at once, and I began to feel more and more contented. Nothing was farther from my intention than to merely take a morning walk in the open air. What had the air to do with my lungs? I was strong as a giant; could stop a dray with my shoulders.

This is a man who has nothing, who cannot pay his rent, who has been rejected from the fire brigade for bad eyesight. And he feels like a giant. The euphoria is pure hunger, the body's first manic response to deprivation, but the narrator does not know that and neither, at first, does the reader. This is the radical insight at the heart of the novel: that we do not experience our physical states as physical states. We experience them as moods, as convictions, as weather. The starving man does not think, "I am light-headed from hunger and therefore feel grandiose." He thinks, "I am strong as a giant." The body lies to the mind, and the mind believes it.

Hamsun understood, decades before psychoanalysis had the vocabulary for it, that consciousness is not transparent to itself. The narrator of *Hunger* does not understand his own behavior. He cannot explain why the sight of a woman with one tooth in her head makes him nauseated ("The long yellow snag looked like a little finger pointing out of her gum"), or why the slow progress of a lame old man ahead of him in the street fills him with violent rage, or why he invents the name "Ylajali" for a woman he has never met and then cannot stop repeating it. These are not motivated actions. They are not symbolic. They are the way a hungry, exhausted, overstimulated mind actually works, lurching from one fixation to the next, converting every passing stimulus into an occasion for extreme feeling.

The Underground and the Street

There is a precursor to Hamsun's narrator, and it is impossible to ignore him. Dostoevsky's Underground Man, that furious, self-lacerating clerk who speaks to us from beneath the floorboards of St. Petersburg in 1864, was the first narrator in fiction to make his own abjection into a kind of performance. He is spiteful and he knows he is spiteful. He sabotages his own friendships, ruins a dinner party, pursues a prostitute only to humiliate her, and then confesses it all in a tone of such aggressive self-awareness that confession itself becomes another form of cruelty.

Hamsun's narrator descends from the Underground Man, but the two are fundamentally different creatures. Dostoevsky's narrator is driven by spite. He destroys his relationships because he cannot bear to be seen as inferior, and he tells us so, at length, with philosophical apparatus. He is a theorist of his own misery. Hamsun's narrator has no theory. He is driven by a pride so extreme that it has become involuntary, reflexive, almost physical, a spasm rather than a position. When he pawns his waistcoat to give money to a stranger, he is not performing generosity out of spite, the way the Underground Man might. He is performing it out of a

need so deep it has no name, a compulsion to be the one who gives rather than the one who receives, even when he has nothing, even when the giving will destroy him.

Watch the extraordinary scene with the old beggar. The narrator catches up to the lame man, slaps his shoulder, and the man whines for money for milk. The narrator, who has nothing, goes and pawns his waistcoat, gives the man the money, and is then outraged when the old man stares at his knees:

My good fellow, you have adopted a most unpleasant habit of staring at a man's knees when he gives you a shilling.

When the confused old man tries to return the money, the narrator stamps on the pavement and insists he keep it, inventing on the spot a fiction that he owed the man a debt. This is not the Underground Man's calculated cruelty. This is something wilder, more involuntary, more modern. The narrator must be generous because he cannot bear to be pitied. He must give because to receive would be to admit what he is. And the lie about the old debt is not a conscious performance; it arrives in his mouth fully formed, the way all his lies do, as though some deeper self were writing the script. Dostoevsky gave us the narrator who knows he is

lying. Hamsun gave us something more unsettling: the narrator who lies and does not quite realize it, who is always one step behind his own performance.

The Body Thinks

What separates *Hunger* most sharply from its precursors, and what makes it most clearly the ancestor of the modernist novel, is its treatment of the body. Before Hamsun, the body in fiction was either a social surface (clothes, beauty, deformity, the visible markers of class) or a site of sensation to be described from the outside. In *Hunger*, the body is the organ of thought. Consciousness does not happen in the head and then get relayed to the body. Consciousness happens in the body, and the head is merely one of the places it passes through.

The most astonishing passage in Part I is the scene with the shoes. The narrator sits on a park bench, unable to write, and lets his gaze fall on his own feet:

I half rise and look down at my feet, and I experience at this moment a fantastic and singular feeling that I have never felt before--a delicate, wonderful shock through my nerves, as if sparks of cold light quivered through them--it

was as if catching sight of my shoes I had met with a kind old acquaintance, or got back a part of myself that had been riven loose.

He begins to weep. He studies the shoes as though they were faces: "I discover that their creases and white seams give them expression--impart a physiognomy to them. Something of my own nature had gone over into these shoes; they affected me, like a ghost of my other I--a breathing portion of my very self."

This is not metaphor. Or rather, it is metaphor that has become experience. The starving body has begun to lose its boundaries, and the narrator's sense of self starts leaking into objects, into his shoes, into the city around him. The shoes are not like a part of himself; they feel like a part of himself, a detached limb that he has just rediscovered. This is the body thinking, the body doing philosophy without the mind's permission. It is precisely the kind of perception Hamsun demanded in his essay: not an idea about experience, but the experience itself, in all its irrationality and physical strangeness.

A similar dissolution occurs later, when the narrator has been walking for hours on an empty stomach:

A singular sense of confusion suddenly darted through my head. I stumbled on, determined not to heed it; but I grew worse and worse, and was forced at last to sit down on a step. My whole being underwent a change, as if something had slid aside in my inner self, or as if a curtain or tissue of my brain was rent in two.

The image of the brain-curtain tearing is hallucinatory, but it is also precise in a way that no clinical description could be. The narrator does not say he felt dizzy or confused. He says that something structural changed inside him, that a curtain tore. This is what hunger does to consciousness, not gradually but all at once, a sudden shift in the architecture of perception, and Hamsun captures it not by describing symptoms but by inhabiting the changed state from within.

The Architecture of Self-Sabotage

Part I establishes what becomes the novel's great recurring structure: a pattern of pride, delusion, collapse, and irrational generosity that repeats with variations like a musical theme. The narrator gets a little money and immediately gives it away. He writes something brilliant and immediately doubts it. He encounters kindness and immediately ruins the encounter with a lie. The pattern is not tragic in the classical sense, because there is no single fatal flaw, no hamartia. The

narrator's pride, his lying, his generosity, his paranoia--these are not flaws in an otherwise sound character. They are the character. They are the weather of his consciousness.

Take the scene at the pawnshop, after he has retrieved his pencil. The pawnbroker is polite, helpful, obliging. And the narrator, seized by some inexplicable compulsion, begins to lie to him:

It was with this pencil that I wrote my dissertation on "Philosophical Cognition," in three volumes.

The lie has no purpose. It gains him nothing. But he cannot stop. The pawnbroker is polite, so the narrator must be extraordinary. A simple transaction must become a performance of importance. And then, having performed importance, he must perform generosity: he voluntarily tries to give money to a woman on the stairs, and is humiliated when he finds his pockets empty. The lying and the generosity come from the same source: an absolute inability to occupy his actual position in the world. He cannot be a starving man retrieving a pencil from a pawnshop. He must be a great author condescending to visit one.

The pattern reaches its fullest expression in the long scene with the blind old man on the bench. The narrator, having invented the name Happolati for a nonexistent landlord, finds

himself building an entire fantasy world around the name: Happolati the agent, Happolati the former Minister of State in Persia, Happolati's beautiful daughter Ylajali (the same invented name he gave the woman on the street), who "reclined on a couch of yellow roses" and had "three hundred slaves." The lies accumulate with a momentum that even the narrator cannot control:

I was entirely absorbed in stories of my own which floated in singular visions across my mental eye. The blood flew to my head, and I roared with laughter.

And then, when the old man accepts everything placidly, the narrator turns furious, precisely because the old man's credulity has robbed him of the friction he needs. The pleasure was not in being believed but in the act of invention, the feeling of creative power. When the old man simply nods along, the narrator explodes: "Hell and fire, man! Do you imagine that I am sitting here stuffing you chock-full of lies?" He is angry at the old man for believing him, because belief makes the lies mundane. The narrator needs his fabrications to astonish. He is, in this moment, both the creator and the destroyer of his own fictions, and the reader sees for the first time that his lying and his writing come from the same desperate wellspring.

Consciousness as Starvation

There is a direct line from Hunger to Fernando Pessoa's *The Book of Disquiet*, that great, unfinished, undatable collection of fragments written by the semi-heteronym Bernardo Soares. Soares, like Hamsun's narrator, wanders a city in a state of perpetual, aestheticized suffering. He is a clerk in Lisbon the way Hamsun's narrator is a writer in Christiania: the occupation is almost irrelevant, a thin pretext for the real activity, which is the ceaseless, self-consuming work of consciousness.

But where Hamsun's narrator is desperate and physical, Soares is cerebral and resigned. Hamsun's narrator runs through the streets, weeps, stamps his feet, gives away his waistcoat. Soares sits at his desk and contemplates the dust motes in a shaft of light. The distance between the two writers is the distance between hunger and satiety, between a consciousness driven to extremity by physical need and a consciousness that has arrived at extremity through sheer attentiveness. Hamsun's narrator would not survive Soares's life; the boredom would kill him faster than the starvation. And Soares would not survive Hamsun's; the physical indignity would be unbearable.

Yet the lineage is unmistakable. What Hamsun discovered in 1890, and what Pessoa inherited and transformed, is the idea that consciousness itself is a kind of hunger. The mind wants. It wants objects, fixations, narratives, fictions. Deprived of food, Hamsun's narrator feeds on everything else: on the old man's newspaper, on the invented name Ylajali, on the imaginary Happolati, on the sight of his own shoes. The mind is omnivorous when the body is starved. It devours details, manufactures stories, generates fantasies, and then, exhausted, collapses into vacancy: "I was conscious of the gaping vacuum in my skull with every fibre of my being. I seemed to myself to be hollowed out from top and toe." The emptiness is not just physical. It is cognitive. The mind, having consumed everything in reach, finds itself empty, a skull with nothing in it, and even that emptiness is experienced with hallucinatory intensity.

This is what Hamsun gave to the novel, and it has never been surpassed, only elaborated. Joyce and Woolf would develop the technical apparatus of stream of consciousness into something more controlled, more architectural, more deliberate. But the raw discovery, the revelation that fiction could track the actual movement of a mind through time, with all its gaps and surges and irrational swerves, belongs to

Hamsun. He found it not in theory but in the body, in the specific derangements of hunger, in the way a starving man's thoughts scatter and concentrate and scatter again.

A Letter Under the Lamp

Part I ends with one of the great scenes in European fiction, though nothing happens in it. The narrator, homeless, freezing, broke, has sneaked back into the attic room he abandoned that morning. On the table he finds a letter. He assumes it is his landlady's final dismissal. He carries it downstairs, puts on his shoes in the dark, walks to a gas lamp, and opens it in the flickering light:

A stream of light, as it were, darts through my breast, and I hear that I give a little cry--a meaningless sound of joy. The letter was from the editor. My story was accepted--had been set in type immediately, straight off! A few slight alterations.... A couple of errors in writing amended.... Worked out with talent ... be printed tomorrow ... half-a-sovereign.

The passage is broken, telegraphic, elliptical. The narrator cannot hold the information in complete sentences. It comes to him in fragments, separated by those breathless ellipses, because that is how joy arrives when you have been expecting catastrophe: not as a steady current but as a

series of shocks. "Worked out with talent"--the editor's polite professional phrase becomes, in the narrator's shattered state, a kind of sacrament. And then the final lines of Part I:

All through the night until the bright dawn I "jodled" about the streets and repeated--"Worked out with talent-- therefore a little masterpiece--a stroke of genius--and half-a-sovereign."

The logic is lunatic and perfect. "Worked out with talent" becomes "a little masterpiece" becomes "a stroke of genius," each phrase inflating the last, the hungry mind doing what it has done all day--transforming the modest into the grandiose. And the half-sovereign comes at the end, tacked on with an "and," as though money were an afterthought, a minor detail appended to the real news, which is that the narrator is a genius. We know, of course, that by tomorrow the money will be gone, the euphoria will collapse, and the pattern will start again. But Hamsun does not tell us this. He leaves the narrator spinning in the street, jodeling into the dark, half-mad with relief and self-love, and the reader is left to feel, with a kind of vertigo, that this joy is as real and as unreliable as everything else that has come before it.

This is what Hamsun invented: a fiction in which the reader inhabits another mind so completely that there is no outside from which to judge it. We are not watching the narrator. We

are thinking with him, starving with him, lying with him, weeping with him, and when the letter comes, we feel the shock of light in our own chests. It is the birth of the interior novel, and it happened not in Paris or London or Dublin but in Christiania, in a bare room papered with old newspapers, in 1890.

Christiania: A City of Ghosts

In the autumn of 1888, a twenty-nine-year-old Norwegian named Knut Hamsun stood on the deck of the transatlantic steamer Thingvalla as it entered the Christiania fjord. The ship was bound for Copenhagen, but it stopped first in Christiania, the small northern capital where Hamsun had once wandered the streets half-starved, scribbling articles that no one would buy, sleeping in doorways and abandoned workshops. He could have disembarked. He chose not to. The city was too close to his skin. He stayed on board, watched the harbor slide past, and continued on to Copenhagen, where he rented a cheap attic room and began to write the novel that would make his name. The memories of Christiania, it turned out, were easier to bear on paper than on foot.

Two years later, in 1890, *Hunger* was published. It is a book set in a very specific city at a very specific moment, and Part II plunges us into that city more deeply than any other section. The narrator wanders from churchyard to harbor bench to guard-house to pawnshop, tracing a map of desperation across Christiania's streets. The city is named. Its

landmarks are real. Its weather is real. But something else is happening, too: the city is dissolving. Under the pressure of starvation and sleeplessness, Christiania becomes a hallucination of itself, a place where policemen clink across the cobblestones like ghosts and empty paper cornets shimmer with imaginary silver. To read Part II is to watch a real city become an unreal one, and to understand that the distance between the two was never very great.

The City on the Fjord

Christiania in 1890 was a city of perhaps 150,000 souls, small by European standards but growing fast, pressed between mountains and sea at the head of its long fjord. It had been called Christiania since 1624, when King Christian IV rebuilt it after a fire, and it would not become Oslo again until 1925. In the 1890s it was a city in the middle of becoming modern. Gas lamps were giving way to electric arc lights along Karl Johan Street, the city's central artery, where fashionable citizens promenaded in the evenings. The harbor at Pipervika, beneath the old fortress of Akershus, was being modernized to accommodate the steamships that now connected Norway to the world. The West Railway Station, opened in 1872, had pulled the city's center of gravity westward. New apartment buildings were going up in Frogner and

Majorstuen. The university was expanding. There were newspapers, theaters, bookshops, cafes. It was the kind of city that believed in progress.

But it was also a city of stark division. The east side, Gronland and Vaterland and the streets climbing toward Ekeberg, was working-class and often wretched. The west side, where Karl Johan led to the Royal Palace, was bourgeois and aspirational. And in between, in attic rooms and abandoned workshops, in churchyards and on harbor benches, lived the city's population of writers and artists and students who belonged to neither world. Hamsun's narrator is one of these people. He is educated, literate, possessed of what he believes is genuine talent. He is also starving, and the city he moves through is indifferent to this fact.

The geography of Part II is traceable. The narrator begins in a churchyard, writing by the last light of evening. He drifts to a bench near the railway bridge by the harbor, the Pipervika waterfront where the ships lay with their masts outlined against the sky. He is taken to the guard-house, perhaps the one near the Town Hall. In the morning he emerges into Young's Market, crosses toward Homandsbyen to find his friend, trudges to Tolbodgaden, then back up to Bernt Akers Street, then down to Pyle Street, then to a pawnshop at Stener's Street. The clock on Our Saviour's Church marks his hours. These are real places. You can still

find most of them in Oslo today, though the city has changed around them. But what matters is not the accuracy of the map. What matters is the way the narrator experiences these streets: as an obstacle course of hope and refusal, each destination promising rescue and delivering nothing.

The Bohemians' Shadow

Hamsun arrived in Christiania at the tail end of one of the most provocative cultural movements in Scandinavian history. In the 1880s, a small circle of writers and artists centered around the anarchist philosopher Hans Jaeger had declared war on bourgeois morality. They called themselves the Kristiania Bohemians. Their manifesto, published in the journal *Impressionisten* in 1889, consisted of nine commandments, the first and most famous of which was: "Thou shalt write thy life." They meant it literally. Jaeger's novel *Fra Kristiania-Bohemen* (From the Christiania Bohemia), published in 1885, was an autobiographical account of the group's experiments in free love, anarchism, and radical honesty. The Norwegian authorities confiscated it immediately, sentenced Jaeger to sixty days in prison, and stripped him of his position as a parliamentary stenographer. The painter Christian Krohg, another member of the circle,

had his novel *Albertine* confiscated the following year. The message from respectable Christiania was clear: write your life, and we will destroy it.

The young Edvard Munch joined this circle in 1884, and it changed everything for him. Jaeger encouraged Munch to abandon realism, to paint not what he saw but what he felt. The bohemians' emphasis on subjective experience, on the primacy of feeling over social convention, would shape the rest of Munch's career. It would also shape Hamsun's.

But here is the crucial distinction that Hunger draws: the bohemian poverty of Jaeger's circle was, at least in part, chosen. They were middle-class rebels slumming in garrets, performing their rejection of bourgeois life as a philosophical statement. The narrator of *Hunger* is not performing anything. His poverty is real, grinding, biological. He chews wood shavings. He sucks on pebbles. He tries to pawn five coat buttons and is laughed out of the shop. The bohemians wrote their lives as an act of defiance; Hamsun's narrator writes his articles because if he does not sell one soon, he will die. The line between artistic defiance and genuine destitution is exactly the fault line that *Hunger* runs along, and Part II is where that line becomes most visible. The narrator is a writer, yes, an intellectual who wears pince-nez and knows the name of the editor of the *Morgenbladet*. But he is also a man who has not eaten in three days, who runs

his forehead into lampposts on purpose, who digs his nails into his palms until they bleed. The bohemians' first commandment was "write thy life." Hamsun did. And what he found there was not liberation but terror.

The Paper Cornet

The most extraordinary scene in Part II, and one of the most extraordinary in all of nineteenth-century fiction, takes place on a harbor bench in the early darkness of a Christiania evening. The narrator, having escaped from the churchyard at closing time, has drifted down to the waterfront. He is carrying a manuscript, a penknife, a bunch of keys, and no money at all. He takes out his papers and, in a movement he describes as "mechanical" and "unconscious," makes a paper cornet from a blank page, folds it carefully to look full, and throws it onto the pavement.

I sat and coaxed myself quite audibly to guess the sum; if
I guessed aright, it was to be mine.

This is already strange. A starving man has made a fake package of money and is now bargaining with himself over its imaginary contents. But the scene has not yet found its true register. A policeman is patrolling nearby. The narrator hears him cough. And then, in a decision that arrives from

some deep recess of mischief, the narrator coughs too, three times, so the policeman will hear and come investigate the cornet.

I was drunk with starvation; my hunger had made me tipsy.

The policeman approaches. He sees the white paper packet on the ground, looking "so white and so full." He picks it up. He opens it with his big hands and looks inside. And the narrator, watching from the bench, laughs silently, maniacally, slapping his thighs:

I laughed, laughed, slapped my thighs, and laughed, like a maniac. And not a sound issued from my throat; my laughter was hushed and feverish to the intensity of tears.

What kind of laughter is this? It is not the laughter of superiority, though the narrator has tricked the policeman. It is not the laughter of joy, though the narrator seems briefly ecstatic. It is the laughter of a man who has discovered that he still has one possession left: the ability to create a fiction. He has nothing. He cannot feed himself. He cannot pay rent. He cannot even give a halfpenny to a street musician. But he can fold a piece of paper into a shape that deceives a

policeman, and in that deception there is a flicker of power, of authorship, of being the one who writes the script rather than the one who suffers it.

The paper cornet is, in miniature, the novel itself. Both are empty containers made to look full. Both are acts of creation born from desperation. And both produce in their audience a response that the creator controls. The policeman opens the cornet and finds nothing; the reader opens *Hunger* and finds everything. The comedy is black, almost unbearable. Denis Johnson, in *Jesus' Son*, would later write scenes of similar register, in which a narrator whose perceptions are warped by drugs and circumstance finds himself in situations that are simultaneously devastating and hilarious. Johnson's narrator, known only as "Fuckhead," witnesses car crashes and overdoses and murders through a haze of chemicals that makes everything both more vivid and less real. Hamsun's narrator has no chemicals, only hunger, but the effect is remarkably similar: a loosening of the grip on ordinary reality that produces comedy where there should be none, beauty where there should be only suffering.

The Harbor at Night

After the policeman walks away, something happens to the narrator that is harder to name than laughter. A drowsy quiet settles over him. He puts his feet up on the bench, leans back, and surrenders to the darkness. The harbor scene that follows is one of the most lyrical passages in the novel, and one of the strangest:

I felt pleasantly empty, untouched by everything around me, and glad not to be noticed by any one. I put my feet up on the seat and leant back. Thus I could best appreciate the well-being of perfect isolation. There was not a cloud on my mind, not a feeling of discomfort, and so far as my thought reached, I had not a whim, not a desire unsatisfied.

This is a man who has not eaten in days. His clothes are insufficient. He has no home to return to, or rather, he has a home, an abandoned tinker's workshop above a stable, but it is so desolate that he dreads it. And yet here, on a bench by the harbor, he experiences what he calls "perfect isolation," a state of contentment so total that it borders on the mystical. The passage is disconcerting precisely because it feels genuine. Hamsun is not being ironic. The narrator really does feel this way, because starvation has burned through all the ordinary anxieties that normally crowd the mind. Hunger, at a

certain point, becomes its own anesthetic. The body, pushed past a threshold of deprivation, releases its grip on worry, on ambition, on desire, and what remains is a strange, unearned peace.

And then, from this peace, the hallucination of Princess Ylajali rises like a tide:

The dark monsters out there will draw me to them when night comes, and they will bear me far across the sea, through strange lands where no man dwells, and they will bear me to Princess Ylajali's palace, where an undreamt-of grandeur awaits me, greater than that of any other man.

Ylajali is one of the novel's recurring phantoms, a name the narrator has invented for a woman he once saw on Karl Johan Street, or perhaps for no one at all. She lives in a palace of amethyst and emerald and ruby, and she has been waiting twenty summers for him, and she will lead him through corridors where crowds cry "Hurrah!" The vision is absurd, grandiose, heartbreaking, and completely serious. It is also, in its way, a piece of urban geography. The narrator is sitting on a bench in Christiania, looking at ships in the harbor, and he is dreaming of another city, a fairy-tale city where he is not hungry and not cold and not forgotten. The dream-city is superimposed on the real city like a transparency. The harbor becomes a launching point; the

ships become monsters that will carry him away; the darkness becomes a corridor leading to the throne room. Christiania has not disappeared. It has been transfigured.

The Scream Across the Water

Three years after *Hunger* was published, Edvard Munch painted *The Scream*. The connection between the two works is not one of direct influence, though both men had breathed the same air. It is, rather, a connection of geography and feeling. In a diary entry written in Nice in January 1892, Munch described the experience that would become the painting: "I was walking along the road with two friends, the sun went down, I felt a gust of melancholy. Suddenly the sky turned a bloody red. I stood there trembling with anxiety, and I felt a vast infinite scream tear through nature."

The road was in Ekebergasen, on the outskirts of Christiania, overlooking the fjord. The bloody sky was above the same harbor where Hamsun's narrator sat on his bench, watching the ships with their black hulls. The anxiety Munch describes, a trembling that comes from nowhere and everywhere, that seems to emanate from the landscape itself, is the same anxiety that saturates Part II of *Hunger*. Both men were channeling something that belonged to the city as much as to themselves. Christiania in the late

nineteenth century was a place where the old certainties, religious, social, economic, were crumbling under the pressure of modernization, and the new certainties had not yet arrived. The electric lights on Karl Johan were brighter than the gas lamps they replaced, but they illuminated the same poverty, the same class divisions, the same gulf between aspiration and reality.

What Munch painted, Hamsun had already written. The narrator of *Hunger* does not scream. His agony is quieter than that. But the landscape is the same: the fjord, the darkening sky, the sense of reality buckling under pressure that is at once personal and cosmic. When the narrator hallucinates Ylajali, the city itself seems to be dreaming. When Munch felt the scream pass through nature, nature itself seemed to be suffering. Both men had found something in Christiania that was larger than autobiography, a dread that belonged to the city, to the century, to the condition of being human in a place that was changing too fast to comprehend.

The Guard-House Comedy

The narrator is eventually awakened from his harbor dream by the policeman, recalled "mercilessly to life and misery." He stumbles through the rain, discovers he has lost his keys, and

ends up at the guard-house, where he must report himself as homeless. What follows is a scene of pure social performance, desperate and inspired in equal measure. He gives a false name, Andreas Tangen, and when asked his occupation, he takes a step forward and says, "firmly, almost solemnly: A journalist." When asked which paper, he names the *Morgenbladet*, one of Christiania's most respectable dailies. He is shown to the reserved section, the cell for gentlemen rather than vagrants, and he exults in his triumph:

I felt ice run down my back at my own boldness, and I clenched my hands to steady myself a bit.

In the morning, he is offered no breakfast ticket, because he has performed his role too well. The other homeless men receive their tickets, the officer on duty repeating to his constable, "Don't forget to give them tickets; they look as if they wanted a meal!" But the narrator, playing the journalist who merely stayed out too late at a cafe, cannot ask for one. His lie has purchased him dignity at the cost of food. He leaves the guard-house with his head held high and his stomach empty, "the carriage of a millionaire, and hands thrust under my coat-tails."

This is the particular cruelty of poverty among the educated. The narrator knows how to impersonate a man of means. He has the vocabulary, the bearing, the cultural

references. He knows the name of the editor Friele. He can deploy the word "Stiftsgaarden." And these skills, which in another context would be assets, become instruments of his own torture. He is too good at pretending to be someone who does not need help, and so he never receives it.

Orwell's Shadow

George Orwell's *Down and Out in Paris and London*, published in 1933, is the most obvious companion text to *Hunger*, and also the most instructive contrast. Orwell, too, writes about educated poverty, about the experience of going hungry in a great city while possessing the ability to describe that hunger in precise prose. Both books traffic in the rituals of destitution: the pawning of belongings, the careful management of shame, the unexpected kindnesses and casual cruelties of strangers, the way hunger distorts time and thought.

But the two books are fundamentally different projects. Orwell is a journalist. His account of poverty is an investigation, a report from the front. He wants to understand how the poor live, and he wants his readers to understand it too. His prose is clear, measured, empirical. When he describes hunger, he describes its physical effects with clinical precision: "Hunger reduces one to an utterly

spineless, brainless condition, more like the after-effects of influenza than anything else." This is a useful observation. It helps us understand something. It is the kind of sentence that might appear in a policy paper.

Hamsun is doing something entirely different. He does not want to explain hunger. He wants to be hunger, to make the reader inhabit a consciousness so distorted by deprivation that the ordinary categories of experience, comedy, tragedy, reason, madness, no longer apply. Where Orwell describes, Hamsun enacts. Consider the moment in Part II when the narrator, having run all the way up Pyle Street in a fit of self-punishment, flings himself down on a step and then forces himself to stand again, "in order to torture myself rightly." This is not a description of how hunger feels. It is a dramatization of the specific madness that hunger produces, the way it turns the self against itself, the way deprivation creates a perverse relationship between the sufferer and his suffering.

Orwell's narrator is always, in some fundamental sense, a tourist in poverty. He has a safety net, even if it is a thin one. He can go home. Hamsun's narrator has no home, or rather, his home is a loft above a tinker's workshop where the snow blows in through the walls. There is no exit, no experiment concluding, no manuscript to deliver to a sympathetic publisher. There is only the next hour, the next bench, the next

humiliation. Orwell wrote about poverty from the outside, with great skill and moral seriousness. Hamsun wrote it from the inside, with the wild, hallucinatory precision of a man remembering his own fever.

The City as Psyche

What makes Part II of *Hunger* so remarkable, finally, is not its depiction of poverty, or its comedy, or its lyricism, but the way it uses the city itself as an instrument of psychological revelation. Christiania in this section of the novel is not a backdrop. It is an extension of the narrator's mind. When he is calm, the harbor is "peaceful and lovely in the murkiness," the sea stretching away "in pearly blueness." When he is agitated, the streets become an obstacle course of strangers who will not help him, doors that will not open, friends who have gone home. When he hallucinates, the ships become monsters and the darkness becomes a corridor to a fairy-tale palace.

This is not pathetic fallacy in the ordinary sense, the convention by which storms reflect anger and sunshine reflects joy. It is something more radical. The city does not reflect the narrator's state of mind. The city is the narrator's state of mind. There is no stable, external Christiania that the narrator perceives correctly or incorrectly. There is only the

Christiania that exists for him in this moment, on this bench, at this stage of starvation. The gas lamps go out and the darkness that follows is not merely dark but "a desperate element to which no one had hitherto paid attention." The nail hole in the wall of his cell is not merely a hole but "a downright intricate and mysterious hole, which I must guard against." Every surface of the city becomes charged with the narrator's hunger, his fear, his strange, intermittent joy.

Consider the long, agonizing sequence in which the narrator traverses the city in search of money. He goes first to the newspaper office: the editor is out. He walks to Homandsbyen to find his friend Hans Pauli Pettersen: Pettersen has moved. He walks to Tolbodgaden to get the new address, then to Bernt Akers Street: Pettersen has gone home for the holidays. He walks to the pastor's house: the pastor is out, his wife has gout. He walks to Cisler the music-seller: Cisler says no. He walks to a yarn shop: the owner is on a mountain tour. He tries to pawn his coat buttons: the pawnbroker laughs. Each of these encounters is a little drama of hope and refusal, and each one takes place at a different point on the map of Christiania. The effect is cumulative and devastating. The city becomes a series of locked doors, a labyrinth of no.

I will tell you one thing, my good Lord God, you are a bungler!

He shouts this in the open street, shaking his fist at the clouds. It is a moment of wild, blasphemous comedy, but it is also a moment of genuine metaphysical protest. The narrator is not merely hungry. He is offended by the structure of reality. The city has been organized, he feels, to maximize his suffering. Every person he needs is absent. Every institution is closed. The very architecture of Christiania seems designed to send him from one empty room to another, each room a little farther from the last, each staircase a little steeper, until he is so exhausted that he cannot stand.

The Ghosts That Remain

Part II ends with rescue, of a sort. Outside the pawnshop, the narrator meets an acquaintance who recognizes him, sees the buttons in his hand, and understands at once. "No; this is really going too far," the man says, and pushes the narrator back inside, pawning his own watch to get five shillings for them both. It is the most human moment in the chapter, and also the most painful, because the narrator has been saved not by his own efforts, not by the city's institutions, not by God's design, but by the accident of someone walking past at the right time. The whole architecture of destitution, the locked doors and absent friends and indifferent strangers, is undone by a coincidence. Five shillings. A pawn ticket. Another few days of life.

Christiania was renamed Oslo in 1925. The harbor was rebuilt, the gas lamps were finally extinguished in 1929, the slums were cleared, the city expanded. Akershus Fortress became a museum. Karl Johan Street is still there, still the city's spine, but the promenading burghers have been replaced by tourists and shoppers. The churchyard where the narrator wrote in the fading light, the bench where he dreamed of Ylajali, the guard-house where he played Cabinet Minister, these places have been absorbed into a modern Scandinavian capital that is prosperous and orderly and, by most measures, among the best cities in the world in which to live.

But the ghosts remain. They remain because Hamsun wrote them down with such hallucinatory precision that they cannot be erased by renovation or prosperity. The starving man on the harbor bench, laughing silently at a policeman who has picked up an empty paper cornet; the sleepless prisoner in his dark cell, probing a nail hole with his penknife and inventing a word that means nothing; the proud, desperate writer running up Pyle Street in a frenzy of self-punishment and then standing, swaying, refusing himself permission to sit down: these figures are permanent residents of the city. They inhabit a Christiania that no longer exists on any map, a city of the mind that Hamsun built from memory

and hunger and something close to genius. It is a city you enter by reading, and once you have been there, you do not entirely leave.

The Theater of Starvation

Part III of *Hunger* opens with a line so disarming it functions almost as a joke: "A week passed in glory and gladness." We know this narrator. We know what his glory looks like and how long his gladness lasts. Sure enough, within a few paragraphs, the week has collapsed. The money is gone. The hair is falling out. The hands must be wrapped in rags because the touch of his own breath on them is unbearable. And yet the narrator is not primarily concerned with survival. He is concerned with something far more volatile, far more dangerous: his dignity.

This is the key to Part III, and perhaps to the novel as a whole. Hamsun's narrator does not merely starve. He performs. Every interaction becomes a scene in a private theater where the audience is himself, where the stakes are not food or shelter but the preservation of an image--the image of a man who does not need help, who refuses charity, who turns aside just so, angling his body to hide the absence of a waistcoat. The comedy, and it is comedy, is that the performance is both magnificent and completely pointless. No one is watching. No one cares whether he has a

waistcoat. But the narrator cares, and his caring is the engine that drives Part III toward its strange, devastating conclusion.

The Commander's Office

The visit to the editor--whom Hamsun calls "the commander," a word that carries overtones of military authority, of command and submission--is one of the finest scenes in nineteenth-century fiction. It is also one of the most painfully recognizable. Any writer who has ever submitted work to a gatekeeper, any person who has ever entered an office knowing they will be judged, will feel the peculiar electricity of this encounter.

The narrator arrives with a piece on Correggio. He has worked on it for days, with hands wrapped in rags, through the cold, through the headaches, through the hair falling in tufts onto his pillow. He enters the editor's office and immediately his attention fixes on the paper basket:

I looked about the little office--busts, prints, cuttings, and an enormous paper-basket, that looked as if it might swallow a man, bones and all. I felt sad at heart at the sight of this monstrous chasm, this dragon's mouth, that always stood open, always ready to receive rejected work, newly crushed hopes.

That "monstrous chasm" is one of Hamsun's great images--the wastebasket as abyss, as the mouth of some indifferent beast that devours manuscripts the way the narrator's hunger devours his body. Every writer knows this basket. It sits in every editorial office, every slush pile, every automated rejection email. The technology changes; the chasm remains.

What follows is a masterpiece of social choreography. The narrator turns aside so the editor will not see that he has no waistcoat. He introduces his manuscript with an apology already built into the sentence: "It is only a little character sketch of Correggio, but perhaps it is, worse luck, not written in such a way that...." The self-deprecation is a shield, but it is also a trap. By lowering expectations, he hopes the work will surprise. By declaring it inadequate, he protects himself from the humiliation of having someone else declare it inadequate.

And then Hamsun does something unexpected. He pauses the narrative to let the narrator actually look at this man:

And so it is thus he looks at close quarters, this man, whose name I had already heard in my earliest youth, and whose paper had exercised the greatest influence upon me as the years advanced. His hair is curly, and his beautiful brown eyes are a little restless. He has a habit of tweaking his

nose now and then. No Scotch minister could look milder than this truculent writer, whose pen always left bleeding scars wherever it attacked.

The narrator is overcome. The tears come. He wants to tell this man how much he has meant to him, to confess his admiration, to beg him not to hurt him. But he does none of this. Instead, when the rejection comes--gently, kindly, with a suggestion to write "something a little more commonplace"--the narrator plays a scene of easy acceptance: "Ah, well, of course, it is not of any use to you," he says, and smiles "to give him the impression that I take it easily."

Then the editor offers him an advance. Money for nothing, a gift from one professional to another. And the narrator, who has not eaten in days, who is losing his hair and wrapping his hands in rags, refuses.

Now, as he had just seen that I was not capable of writing, this offer humiliated me somewhat, and I answered: "No, thanks; I can pull through yet a while, thanking you very much, all the same. Good-day!"

This is devastating precisely because the editor is not cruel. The system, in this moment, is not indifferent. A kind man is offering a reasonable kindness, and the narrator's pride--his need to perform self-sufficiency, even as he starves--turns it

away. The tragedy of Part III is not that the world is hostile. It is that the world occasionally extends a hand, and the narrator cannot bring himself to take it.

The Costume of Poverty

The sociologist Erving Goffman spent his career studying what he called "impression management"--the idea that all social life is performance, that we are constantly presenting a self to others, adjusting our behavior based on the audience, the setting, the stakes. Goffman's insight was that this is not dishonesty. It is the basic mechanism of social existence. We all perform. The question is what happens when the costume fails.

For Hamsun's narrator, poverty is not merely a material condition. It is a theatrical catastrophe. The props are gone--the waistcoat, the overcoat, the clean hands, the proper address. Without these things, every social interaction becomes what Goffman would call a "scene"--a moment where the performance breaks down and the backstage reality becomes visible. The narrator knows this. He turns his body to hide the missing waistcoat. He lies about why he has no overcoat. He invents names and addresses. He pretends to be a pastor to a prostitute. He claims the woman he

walked with is his fiancée. He constructs, out of nothing, an elaborate social identity that will survive each encounter for precisely as long as the encounter lasts.

The genius of Hamsun's treatment is that these performances are not strategic deceptions. They are reflexive, almost biological. The narrator lies the way a wounded animal drags itself to cover. He is not trying to gain advantage. He is trying to exist in public without the armor that money provides. When he meets the woman in black--Ylajali, as he names her--his first thought is not desire but exposure:

Badly dressed, as I unfortunately was, I might protect her through the dark streets; but I had an undefined fear that it perhaps might cost me something; a glass of wine, or a drive, and I had no money left at all.

And later, walking beside her, feeling the warmth of her body, smelling her perfume, the narrator's mind circles back to the same terror:

Suppose she were to take it into her head to wish to go there? Into that blaze of light, with the crowd of people. Why, she would be filled with shame; I would drive her out again, with my shabby clothes, and lean face; perhaps she might even notice that I had no waistcoat on....

The missing waistcoat haunts Part III like a recurring nightmare. It is such a small absence--a single garment--but it represents everything. Without it, the narrator cannot enter lit spaces. Without it, he cannot open his coat. Without it, he is not a writer visiting an editor, or a young man courting a woman, but a visible pauper, a man whose body betrays what his words try to conceal.

The Comedy of the Losing Proposition

There is a long tradition, in Western literature, of the starving writer. But most versions of this story are either sentimental--the garret as romantic staging ground--or moralistic, designed to illustrate the cruelty of an indifferent society. Hamsun does something different. He makes starvation funny. Not funny in spite of being terrible, but funny because it is terrible, because the narrator's responses to his situation are so wildly disproportionate, so theatrically elaborate, that they become a kind of dark vaudeville.

Consider the scene with the prostitute. The narrator, penniless and starving, accosts a woman on Carl Johann Street, walks with her a few paces, then announces he has no money. She searches his pockets. She asks if his eyeglasses are gold. They are not. "Then go to blazes with you!" she says. She then calls him back--"You can come with me all the

same!"--and the narrator, mortified, invents an entire persona on the spot: he is a pastor, he has only been testing her virtue, and his parting words are "Depart, and sin no more!" He then walks away congratulating himself:

I rubbed my hands with delight over my happy notion, and soliloquized aloud, "What a joy there is in going about doing good actions." Perhaps I had given this fallen creature an upward impulse for her whole life.

This is comedy of the highest order--not because the narrator is a fool, but because his need to salvage dignity from every encounter is so fierce that it produces absurdity. He cannot even be rejected by a prostitute without constructing a moral victory. The performance must go on, even when the audience is a bewildered stranger and the theater is a dark street at midnight.

Roberto Bolano understood this comedy. His novels are populated by writers who maintain absurd dignity in the face of indifference--the visceral realists of *The Savage Detectives*, those young poets wandering the Mexican desert, broke and brilliant, convinced that literature matters even as the world demonstrates, with mechanical regularity, that it does not. Arturo Belano and Ulises Lima are Hamsun's narrator's grandchildren. They share his conviction that the literary life is worth the suffering, and they share his gift for

turning that suffering into performance. In 2666, Bolano sends his literary scholars on a quest across continents, and the joke--the deep, structural joke--is that their scholarly obsession is a form of the same compulsive meaning-making that drives Hamsun's narrator to write about Correggio while his body eats itself alive. The literary life, in both Hamsun and Bolano, is a fundamentally losing proposition pursued with the intensity of a calling.

What Remains When Everything Is Stripped Away

Part III asks a question that would haunt twentieth-century literature: what is left of a person when status, comfort, and social standing are removed? The narrator has lost nearly everything. His hair. His waistcoat. His ability to keep food down. His capacity for sustained thought. And yet something persists--something fierce and self-destructive and, in its way, admirable. He refuses the editor's advance. He gives stolen money to a cake vendor. He confesses his crime to the bewildered shopkeeper. He curses God in a back alley with an eloquence that suggests the thing consuming him has not yet touched the part that makes sentences.

J.M. Coetzee explored this question with surgical precision in *Disgrace*. David Lurie, stripped of his university position, his reputation, his daughter's safety, his very sense of himself as a civilized man, refuses at every turn to perform the contrition that would restore him. He will not apologize to the disciplinary committee. He will not explain himself. He will not pretend to be reformed. Like Hamsun's narrator, he maintains an elaborate performance of dignity while his life collapses around him--but Lurie's performance is one of refusal, of withholding, where Hamsun's narrator's performance is one of desperate invention.

The connection between the two characters is this: both discover that dignity, once stripped of its material supports, becomes something volatile and strange. It does not disappear. It mutates. Lurie's dignity becomes a kind of cold stubbornness. Hamsun's narrator's dignity becomes a kind of manic theater. Both men would rather suffer than admit to suffering. Both novels suggest that this refusal is simultaneously the most human and the most self-defeating impulse we possess.

When the narrator finally encounters the commandor again, by accident, at the railway wharf, he is at the very bottom:

I was standing face to face with the "Commandor." I get devil-may-care--brazen. I take yet a step farther from the wall in order to make him notice me. I do not do it to awake his compassion, but to mortify myself, place myself, as it were, on the pillory.

This is a remarkable psychological reversal. Having spent the entire novel hiding his poverty, the narrator now displays it. The performance has flipped: instead of pretending to be well, he performs his wretchedness. He steps forward so the editor can see what he has become. And the editor, that kind man with the curly hair and restless brown eyes, simply gives him money: "The Lord preserve you, man, it will never do for you to go and starve yourself to death."

The narrator takes it this time. He is too broken not to. But he cannot thank the man--his legs fail him, his voice is too weak, and the editor walks away. The narrator is left standing on the pavement, weeping, inspecting the coin on both sides as if it might not be real.

The Confessional Impulse

Karl Ove Knausgaard has spoken often of Hamsun as his primary literary ancestor, and nowhere is the inheritance more visible than in Part III of *Hunger*. Knausgaard's six-volume *My Struggle* is built on the same confessional engine:

the relentless, almost compulsive transformation of daily experience--much of it humiliating, much of it banal--into prose. Both writers weaponize the mundane. A trip to a shop, a conversation with a stranger, the act of brushing loose hairs from a coat collar: in both Hamsun and Knausgaard, these small moments are rendered with such intensity that they become unbearable.

The difference--and it is a crucial one--is the safety net. Knausgaard writes from the security of middle-class Norway. His shame is real, but it is the shame of a man who has a home, a family, food in the refrigerator. He is ashamed of his drinking, his failed first marriage, his treatment of his children, his feelings about his dead father. These are serious matters. But they are not existential in the way Hamsun's shame is existential. When Hamsun's narrator wraps his hands in rags and sits down to write, the failure to produce a good sentence is not merely a professional disappointment. It is a death sentence. The essay on Correggio is not an intellectual exercise. It is the thing that stands between the narrator and the bone he will gnaw in a dark alley, weeping and vomiting, cursing God.

Knausgaard understood this. In the first volume of *My Struggle*, he describes the act of writing as a stripping away, a deliberate removal of the social masks that protect us. Hamsun's narrator has the masks stripped away by

circumstance--by poverty, by hunger, by the slow erosion of the body. The result, in both cases, is a prose of terrifying intimacy. We are not reading about a character. We are reading the inside of a mind that has nowhere left to hide.

But where Knausgaard's confession is ultimately an act of control--he shapes the narrative, he decides what to reveal, he publishes from a position of literary celebrity--Hamsun's narrator is confessing under duress. The confession is involuntary, like the vomiting. The truth comes up because it cannot be kept down.

The Scene on the Carpet

The evening with Ylajali is the novel's most agonizing performance. The narrator has money now, the commandor's half-sovereign. He has shaved. He arrives at her apartment. She teases him, chases him around a table, criticizes his reticence. And then she asks why his hair is falling out, and the narrator, instead of lying--instead of performing the role of the dissolute young rake she seems to expect--tells the truth. He tells her everything. The starvation, the stolen money, the bone in the alley.

She sat and listened, with open mouth, pale, frightened, her shining eyes completely bewildered.

The confession destroys the evening. Ylajali retreats. She murmurs "the Lord preserve me" at intervals. And then she says the words that cut deepest: "I can't be sure that you are not insane."

What follows is one of the most extraordinary passages in the novel. The narrator, standing at her door, delivers a monologue that is simultaneously a love speech, a self-defense, and a breakdown. He asks to kneel before her. He points to a specific rose in the carpet pattern where he would kneel. He insists he is not insane. He insists he is not moving. He describes his own stillness with the precision of a stage direction:

I stood just as immovable as I stand now when I point out the place to you where I would have knelt before you, over there on the crimson rose in the carpet. I don't even point with my finger. I don't point at all; I let it be, not to frighten you.

This is a man performing sanity. Every word is calibrated to prove that he is calm, rational, in control--and the very intensity of the performance proves the opposite. He is a man standing in a woman's apartment, describing the specific floor tile on which he would prostrate himself, insisting that the act of not kneeling demonstrates his reasonableness. The scene is funny and terrible in equal

measure, and it contains the entire novel in miniature: a man using language to construct an identity that his body and circumstances are systematically dismantling.

The Audience of One

What makes Part III so strange, so modern, is that the narrator's performances are not really for other people. The editor does not care about the waistcoat. The prostitute does not care about his moral lecture. Ylajali, in the end, seems to embrace him despite everything. The performances are for the narrator himself. He is his own audience, his own critic, his own judge. When he gives the stolen money to the cake vendor, he does not do it because the cake vendor needs it. He does it because he needs to feel honest again. When he confesses to the shopkeeper, he does not do it for justice. He does it for the performance of confession, the theater of moral rectitude.

This is what separates Hamsun from Dostoevsky, with whom he is often compared. Dostoevsky's underground man performs for the reader, for posterity, for God. Hamsun's narrator performs for an audience of one--himself--and the performance is never adequate. He can never quite convince himself. The role shifts too quickly: he is a dignified writer, then a thief, then a penitent, then a pastor, then a lover, then

a madman, then a man who is not a madman. Each identity lasts only as long as the scene requires, and then the curtain falls and he is back in the cold room, with the hair on the pillow and the hands in rags.

Part III ends with the narrator backing out of Ylajali's apartment. "I crushed her in my arms, stepped back, rushed to the door, and went out backwards." It is the exit of a man who cannot turn his back on beauty even as he retreats from it. Even in departure, the performance continues. Even in loss, the gesture must be right.

This is the theater of starvation: a one-man show, performed for an empty house, in which the actor is slowly being consumed by the role. The audience does not arrive. The reviews never come. And the actor, magnificent and doomed, keeps performing, because the alternative--to stop, to sit down, to admit that the show is over--is the one thing he cannot do.

After Hunger

A novel can end in triumph or defeat, in marriage or death, in revelation or collapse. *Hunger* ends in none of these. It ends in departure. The narrator signs aboard a ship bound for England, a man with no experience claiming he can do anything. He is bluffing, of course, as he has bluffed his way through the entire book. But this time the bluff works. The captain says he can have a try. And then, in the novel's final paragraph, we get one of the most quietly devastating sentences in modern fiction:

Out in the fjord I dragged myself up once, wet with fever and exhaustion, and gazed landwards, and bade farewell for the present to the town--to Christiania, where the windows gleamed so brightly in all the homes.

That is the whole of the ending. There is no resolution, no lesson, no earned wisdom. There is a sick man on a ship looking back at a city full of lighted windows. The windows gleam in all the homes--all the homes that were never his, all the warmth he stood outside of for the length of the novel. It is an image of belonging seen from the position of

permanent exclusion. The narrator does not overcome hunger. He flees it. He does not find his place in the world. He sails away from the only place he knows.

Compare this to the endings of the other great novels of dislocation. The Great Gatsby closes with boats borne back ceaselessly into the past--a gorgeous, oratorical sweep that turns one man's failure into the condition of American longing itself. The last paragraph of Dubliners finds Gabriel Conroy watching the snow fall "upon all the living and the dead," dissolving boundaries in a universal white silence. Even Beckett's Molloy, for all its radical indeterminacy, ends with the strange calm of a man who has stopped struggling: "I don't know. I don't know." Each of these endings achieves a kind of formal grandeur, a sense that the sentence itself has become large enough to contain more than one life.

Hamsun's ending does something different. It stays small. It stays with the particular. Those gleaming windows are not a metaphor for the human condition. They are windows, in a specific city, seen by a specific man who is running a fever. The power of the sentence lies in its plainness, and in what it does not say. The narrator does not tell us he is heartbroken. He does not tell us he is relieved. He bids farewell "for the present," as if he might come back, as if this were a temporary arrangement. It is the kind of lie people tell themselves when they are leaving forever.

The Mind Betrays Itself

Before the departure, though, comes the scene that might be the true climax of the novel--if a novel this formless can be said to have a climax. It is not a dramatic confrontation or a romantic catastrophe. It is a grocery bill.

The landlady asks the narrator to check her accounts. A simple column of figures: loaves at two and a half pence, a lamp chimney at three, soap, butter. He adds the numbers, finds the total correct, and she asks him to check each line individually. And then he hits it:

Finally, I came to a dead stop at the following entry--"3. 5/16ths of a pound of cheese at 9d." My brain failed me completely; I stared stupidly down at the cheese, and got no farther.

Five-sixteenths of a pound of cheese. Five ounces, the landlady explains--it is simply how Dutch cheese is sold. The narrator claims to understand, tries once more, and cannot do it. The arithmetic is elementary. A child could manage it. But hunger has colonized the last territory he believed secure. His mind, the one instrument he possesses, the faculty on which his identity as a writer depends, has buckled.

What makes the scene so devastating is the narrator's response. He does not weep or rage. He performs. He moves his lips, mutters numbers aloud, slides his finger down the column of figures as though steadily approaching a result. He is acting the part of a man who can think. And the landlady--this practical, pregnant, overworked woman--sees through him at once.

She remarked that perhaps I was not accustomed to reckon in sixteenths; she mentioned also that she must only apply to some one who had a knowledge of sixteenths, to get the account properly revised.

Her tact is more lacerating than cruelty would be. She speaks "not in any hurtful way to make me feel ashamed, but thoughtfully and seriously." She has simply reclassified him. He is no longer a lodger with prospects. He is a man who cannot add. And then, on her way out, the small devastating sentence: "Excuse me for taking up your time then."

The narrator's attempt to recover from this scene is one of the great passages of self-deception in literature. He reassures himself furiously: he noticed the landlady was pregnant, didn't he? He can hear a song from the kitchen and identify whether it is sung in tune. He can observe children quarreling in the street and follow every detail. Therefore his mind must be sound. The cheese was an anomaly. It was the

cheese's fault, really--Dutch cheese with cloves and pepper, the smell alone enough to finish a man. "Set me, if you like, at five-sixteenths of good dairy butter," he tells himself. "That is another matter."

The comedy here is savage because the narrator's logic is not wrong, exactly. He can observe, he can notice, he can perceive with hallucinatory sharpness. What he can no longer do is the plodding, sequential, unglamorous work of thought. He can see the world but he cannot operate within it. Hunger has separated perception from function, the artist's eye from the citizen's competence. He is becoming a creature of pure consciousness with no practical capacity whatsoever--a condition that looks, from one angle, like madness, and from another, like the logical endpoint of the literary vocation pushed past all sustainable limits.

The Boy Who Became Hamsun

Knut Hamsun was born Knud Pedersen in 1859, in the village of Lom in the Gudbrandsdal valley, the fourth of seven children. His father was a tailor and smallholder. The family was poor. At nine, Hamsun was sent to live with an uncle who beat him and worked him relentlessly. His formal education was negligible. He left home as a teenager and worked as a

peddler, a shoemaker's apprentice, a schoolteacher, a road laborer, and a sheriff's assistant before emigrating to America in 1882.

The American years are crucial. Hamsun crossed the Atlantic twice, spending roughly four years in the upper Midwest and the East Coast. He was a farmhand in North Dakota, a streetcar conductor in Chicago, a clerk, a lecturer, a journalist in Minneapolis. He was nobody. He was a Norwegian immigrant working menial jobs in a country that had no use for his ambitions, and the experience marked him permanently. When he returned to Scandinavia and settled in Copenhagen in 1888, he was twenty-nine years old, had published nothing of consequence, and was furious--at America, at the literary establishment, at the nineteenth-century realism of Ibsen and Zola that he considered exhausted and dishonest.

Hunger was published in 1890, when Hamsun was thirty-one. It drew directly on his experience of near-starvation in Christiania in the mid-1880s, between his two American sojourns. The novel made him famous immediately. It was recognized, even by hostile reviewers, as something unprecedented--a work that had dispensed with plot, social context, and moral instruction in favor of the pure, terrifying intimacy of a single consciousness under siege. Over the next

decade Hamsun produced *Mysteries*, *Pan*, and *Victoria*, consolidating a body of work that would reshape European fiction.

In 1920, he was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature for *Growth of the Soil*, his pastoral epic about a pioneer farming the Norwegian wilderness. The prize honored a different Hamsun than the one who wrote *Hunger*--an older man who had turned from the city to the land, from psychology to agrarianism, from the restless modernist to the conservative sage. But the Nobel made him the most celebrated Scandinavian writer of his age, and it is the Nobel that makes what followed so impossible to look away from.

The Catastrophe

Hamsun's affinity for Germany was longstanding. He had been a Germanophile and Anglophobe since the First World War. He admired what he saw as the discipline and depth of German culture, and he despised the British Empire with an intensity that bordered on obsession. When the Nazis rose to power, Hamsun did not merely tolerate them. He embraced them. He saw in National Socialism a kinship with his own agrarian ideals, his contempt for urban modernity, his belief in the primacy of blood and soil.

When Germany invaded Norway on April 9, 1940, Hamsun supported the occupation. He wrote articles and gave interviews urging his countrymen to lay down their arms. He praised Vidkun Quisling's collaborationist government. He donated his Nobel medal to Joseph Goebbels as a gesture of admiration. On June 26, 1943, he traveled to Berchtesgaden and met Adolf Hitler in person. The meeting, by most accounts, went badly: Hamsun was eighty-three, nearly deaf, and used the audience to harangue Hitler about the brutality of the German administrator in Norway, Josef Terboven. Hitler was reportedly enraged. But Hamsun left the meeting unshaken in his convictions.

The most damning document came last. On May 7, 1945--one week after Hitler's death, the same day Germany surrendered--Hamsun published an obituary in the newspaper *Aftenposten*. He called Hitler "a warrior for humankind and a preacher of the gospel of justice for all nations." He called him "a reformer of the highest order." This was not a private delusion confided to a diary. It was a public eulogy for a man whose regime had murdered six million Jews, published in a Norwegian newspaper on the day the war in Europe ended. Hamsun was eighty-five years old. He knew exactly what he was doing.

After the liberation, Hamsun was arrested and held in a hospital. A psychiatric examination lasting 119 days concluded that he suffered from "permanently impaired mental faculties"--a diagnosis that enraged him and that many later scholars have questioned. The finding allowed the Norwegian authorities to avoid a full treason trial. Instead, a civil case was brought, and in 1948 Hamsun was ordered to pay 325,000 kroner in restitution. He was financially ruined. He spent his last years on his farm at Norholm, nearly deaf, increasingly isolated, writing one final book: *On Overgrown Paths*, published in 1949, a lucid and combative memoir that many readers took as evidence his mental faculties had never been impaired at all. He died on February 19, 1952, at the age of ninety-two.

The Problem That Will Not Resolve

So here is the case. The man who wrote the most empathetic portrait of poverty and psychological suffering in modern fiction--a book that enters the consciousness of a starving man with such fidelity that the reader can feel the walls of the stomach contracting--became a public advocate for a regime that starved millions to death in camps and ghettos and occupied cities. The author of the cheese scene, who understood better than anyone what it means to have your mind dismantled by deprivation, praised the architects of

industrialized deprivation. This is not a matter of youthful indiscretion or political naivety. Hamsun supported the Nazis throughout the war, into his eighties, and never fully recanted.

The conversation about art and the moral failures of artists is by now well-worn. We have had it about Ezra Pound, who broadcast fascist propaganda from Rome. About Louis-Ferdinand Celine, whose antisemitic pamphlets remain so vile they were kept out of print in France for decades. About Martin Heidegger, whose philosophical language was entangled with Nazi ideology in ways scholars are still parsing. About Richard Wagner, whose operas Hitler adored and whose antisemitism was programmatic and vicious.

Hamsun's case is in some ways worse, because the gap between the art and the politics is so vertiginous. Pound's poetry is authoritarian in its aesthetics--its drive to master all of culture, to compel fragments into order. You can see a line, however crooked, from the Cantos to the radio broadcasts. Celine's novels are powered by the same raging contempt that fueled his pamphlets. But *Hunger*? *Hunger* is a book about powerlessness. About the dissolution of the self under pressure. About what it feels like to be nobody, to have nothing, to be at the mercy of a body you cannot feed and a city that does not care. There is nothing in the novel--not one sentence, not one image--that points toward fascism. And yet the man who wrote it became a fascist.

There are explanations, of course. Hamsun's Anglophobia, his agrarian romanticism, his belief that modern democracy was decadent, his lifelong hostility to the urban and the cosmopolitan. His increasing deafness, which isolated him from the world and may have made him more susceptible to ideology. His vanity, which was immense, and which the Nazis flattered expertly--Goebbels ordered a hundred thousand copies of his works printed after their meeting. But explanations are not resolutions. You cannot read the cheese scene and then read the Hitler obituary and make the two cohere. The incoherence is the point. It is the permanent scandal of Hamsun's life, and no amount of biographical context will dissolve it.

Isaac Bashevis Singer, a Nobel laureate himself and a Yiddish writer whose family was destroyed in the Holocaust, wrote that "the whole modern school of fiction in the twentieth century stems from Hamsun." He did not say this lightly. He did not say it in ignorance of Hamsun's politics. He said it because it was true, and because Singer understood that the history of literature is not a rewards ceremony for the virtuous.

The Enormous Shadow

The influence of *Hunger* on twentieth-century fiction is so pervasive that it has become invisible, like a river that has been diverted into so many channels that the original source is forgotten.

Franz Kafka read Hamsun early, and the mark is unmistakable. *The Metamorphosis*, published in 1915, takes the condition of Hamsun's narrator--a man trapped in a body that is failing him, increasingly alien to the world around him, dependent on the grudging charity of others--and literalizes it as insect transformation. Gregor Samsa wakes as a beetle; Hamsun's narrator wakes as something almost as monstrous, a thinking being who can no longer think. Kafka's 1922 story "A Hunger Artist" is an even more direct descendant: a man who makes a profession of starving, who discovers that his art consists precisely of deprivation, and who confesses at the end that he fasted only because he never found any food he liked. The hunger artist is Hamsun's narrator translated into parable--the writer whose medium is his own emptiness.

Samuel Beckett's tramps arrive from the same lineage. Vladimir and Estragon in *Waiting for Godot* are Hamsun's narrator stripped even of the city--placed on a bare road with a single tree, waiting for something that will not come. They bicker, they clown, they contemplate suicide, they eat a

carrot. The structure of their days is the structure of Hunger: expectation, disappointment, the irrational persistence of hope, the comedy of desperation. Beckett takes Hamsun's single man and splits him into two, because even solitude, pushed far enough, becomes a kind of dialogue with oneself.

Henry Miller called Hamsun "the Dickens of my generation"--a remark that sounds paradoxical until you consider what Miller meant by it. Not the Dickens of social panorama and moral feeling, but the Dickens of sheer narrative energy, of prose so alive to physical experience that it makes the reader hungry, cold, footsore, euphoric. Miller's *Tropic of Cancer*, written in Paris in the early 1930s, is a book about a writer who has nothing and wants everything, who scrounges meals and sleeps in borrowed beds and talks incessantly about art and sex and the magnificent failure of his own ambitions. It is *Hunger* transplanted to Montparnasse, with the Protestantism removed and the libido turned up.

Charles Bukowski acknowledged the debt more bluntly. A character in his novel *Women* calls Hamsun the greatest writer who ever lived. Bukowski's *Factotum*, published in 1975, takes Hamsun's wandering narrator and sets him loose in wartime and postwar America, drifting from one miserable job to the next, writing in cheap rooms, drinking everything in sight. Where Hamsun's narrator starves with a kind of

metaphysical grandeur, Bukowski's Henry Chinaski starves with a hangover. But the architecture is the same: the episodic, picaresque structure of failure, the comedy of a man who cannot quite be destroyed.

Paul Auster wrote an essay called "The Art of Hunger" in 1970, and the title became a kind of mission statement. In it, Auster argued that Hamsun "walks straight into the twentieth century" by translating the world of art into the world of the body. Auster's *Moon Palace*, published in 1989, follows a young man in 1960s New York through a process of self-starvation and dispossession that mirrors Hamsun's narrator almost scene for scene. The difference is that Auster's protagonist knows he is reenacting a literary tradition. He has read the books. He is starving in the library, surrounded by all the other stories of starvation. This self-consciousness is itself a measure of Hamsun's influence: by 1989, you could not write a novel about a starving writer without writing, in some sense, about *Hunger*.

The Starving Writer in the Age of Precarity

There is a temptation, with any classic, to declare it "more relevant than ever." Usually the claim is lazy. But with *Hunger* there is something to it that goes beyond the perennial appeal of a good novel.

Hamsun's narrator is a freelance writer. He has no employer, no safety net, no institutional affiliation. He produces work on speculation and submits it to editors who may or may not buy it. His income is irregular. His housing is precarious. He is one rejected article away from the street. He performs competence and well-being for the people around him while privately coming apart. He is, in the language of the twenty-first century, a gig worker. He is a content creator *avant la lettre*--producing words no one has commissioned, pitching stories no one has asked for, maintaining the fiction of professional viability while his shoes fall apart and his hair falls out.

The particular shame Hamsun captures--the shame of educated poverty, of downward mobility, of being intelligent enough to understand precisely how badly things are going--has not diminished. If anything, it has spread. The narrator's experience, once exotic enough to shock Scandinavian readers, is now recognizable to millions of people in the developed world who hold advanced degrees and cannot pay their rent. The journalist writing for publications that fold. The adjunct professor teaching four courses at three institutions for less than a living wage. The novelist with an MFA and a novel that does not sell. The distance between Hamsun's Christiania and the contemporary economy has not widened. It has collapsed.

What remains most modern about *Hunger* is not the social condition it describes but the psychology it renders. The narrator does not simply suffer. He suffers and watches himself suffer. He narrates his own degradation with a mixture of horror, fascination, and perverse amusement. He lies to others about his circumstances and then lies to himself about why he lied. He performs generosity he cannot afford. He rejects help he desperately needs. He oscillates between grandiosity and self-loathing so rapidly that the reader can barely keep up. This is not nineteenth-century realism. It is the texture of a mind under unbearable pressure, and it sounds remarkably like the interior monologue of anyone who has ever refreshed their bank balance at three in the morning, knowing what they would find.

The Ship

The novel's last movement is swift and strange. After the landlady throws him out, after the drama is torn to shreds, after the half-sovereign from Ylajali is thrown in the landlady's face in a gesture of suicidal pride, after the hallucinatory scene with the potatoes he insists are cabbages--swearing by the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost that they are cabbages--after all of this, the narrator simply walks to the harbor and asks if a ship needs a man.

He has no sailing experience. He is feverish, emaciated, half-blind without the glasses he furtively pockets to appear younger. But the captain of the *Copegoro*, a Russian barque bound for Leith and then Cadiz, takes him on. "Have a try at it," the captain says. "If it doesn't work, well, we can part in England."

There is no catharsis in this ending. No recognition scene, no reconciliation. The narrator does not learn anything. He does not grow. He escapes, and even the escape is provisional--the captain's conditional phrasing ("if it doesn't work") echoing all the conditional arrangements that have collapsed throughout the book. The ship is not salvation. It is another temporary arrangement, another bluff, another room that might be taken away.

And yet the ending is not hopeless. Or rather, it is not only hopeless. The narrator, who has lost everything--his lodging, his manuscript, his shoes, his ability to do arithmetic, the woman he thinks he loves--still has the capacity to act. He walks to the harbor. He asks a question. He boards a ship. These are small gestures, almost negligible, but they are not nothing. Hamsun understood that survival is not a grand narrative. It is a series of small, improbable decisions made by people who have every reason to stop making them.

The gleaming windows of Christiania, seen from the fjord, are the last image the novel gives us. They are beautiful and they are cruel. They represent everything the narrator wanted and could not have: warmth, shelter, belonging, a desk, a lamp, a room of his own where the spirit might move him and the allegory might be finished. The windows gleam "in all the homes"--that phrase, "all the homes," carrying the weight of everything the narrator's homelessness has meant. He is not looking back at a city. He is looking back at the idea of a life he was never granted.

Hamsun was thirty-one when he published this ending. He would live another sixty-two years, win the Nobel Prize, write a dozen more books, buy a grand estate, meet Adolf Hitler, eulogize him in print, be tried for treason, be declared mentally impaired, write a final book proving he was nothing of the kind, and die in his bed at ninety-two. The young man on the ship became one of the most celebrated and most reviled writers of the twentieth century. The novel he left behind--this small, ferocious, funny, agonizing book about a man who could not feed himself--became the headwater of modern fiction's deepest stream: the literature of the self at the end of its resources, the mind turning on itself in the dark.

The windows still gleam. The ship sails on. The hunger does not end.